

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

PHASE SIX

Rachel Notley NDP • 2015 – 2019

The Restoration That Was Allowed To Be Undone

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

The Notley NDP Era, 2015 – 2019

The only sustained reversal-period of the entire forty-seven years this document covers. The only era in which AISH was indexed to inflation by statute. The first non-PC Alberta government since 1971. And the era whose gains were undone within fifteen months of the government that followed it.

On May 5, 2015, after forty-four years of unbroken Progressive Conservative government in Alberta, Rachel Notley's New Democratic Party won fifty-four of eighty-seven seats. The Notley NDP held the legislature from May 24, 2015 to April 30, 2019. Within those four years, the government enacted: legislated CPI indexation of AISH and three other income-support programs (the only time this has been done in Alberta's history); the first major AISH base-rate increase since 2012; the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act and the appointment of Alberta's first Advocate for Persons with Disabilities; the \$25-per-day childcare pilot expanded to 122 centres; the increase of Alberta's minimum wage to \$15 per hour (the highest in Canada at the time); a major PDD program review; and asset-limit reforms designed to remove the cliff-edge effects of partial income on AISH and Income Support recipients.

This is, by a wide margin, the most positive era for the disability community of any Alberta government in the period this document covers, including the Lougheed founding era. It is also the era whose gains proved the most rapidly reversible. By November 2019 — within seven months of the UCP taking office — the AISH indexation had been suspended by Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act). By April 2021 — within two years of the Notley loss — the \$25-per-day childcare pilot had been wound up. By the end of the Kenney UCP government in 2022, every major Notley-era social-policy initiative had been either reversed, frozen, or restructured downward.

The Notley era is, therefore, the chapter that most clearly demonstrates the structural argument this document has been building since Phase One. Disability supports are not, in any binding institutional sense, secure. They are secure only for as long as the current premier chooses to make them secure. Rachel Notley's government chose to make them secure for four years. The premier who replaced her chose not to. The community absorbed the cost of the difference. That is what the comparative-summary table of this piece preserves — and it is why the campaign you are reading the historical record of exists.

Political context

Rachel Anne Notley was born April 17, 1964 in Edmonton, the eldest of three children of Sandra Wilkinson and Grant Notley — the latter of whom served as leader of the Alberta NDP from 1968 until his death in a plane crash on October 19, 1984, when Rachel was twenty years old. Grant Notley had been the NDP's sole MLA in the Alberta Legislature for most of his tenure, and his political legacy was understood in NDP circles to be unfinished. His daughter completed it.

Notley graduated from the University of Alberta and earned her law degree at Osgoode Hall Law School. She was called to the Bar of Ontario in 1994 and the Bar of Alberta in 1997. Her professional career — labour law, workers' compensation advocacy, and political staff positions in NDP governments in British Columbia and federal Liberal/NDP environments — was structurally distinct from the corporate-law and career-politician backgrounds of most of her Alberta predecessors.

She was elected MLA for Edmonton-Strathcona in March 2008 and re-elected in 2012. In October 2014, she won the Alberta NDP leadership. On May 5, 2015, the NDP's election victory was a structural shock to Alberta political analysis: 54 NDP seats to 21 Wildrose, 10 PC, and 1 each for the Liberals and the Alberta Party (87 seats total). Notley was sworn in as Alberta's 17th Premier on May 24, 2015, becoming the first non-PC Alberta premier since 1971.

Her government took office at the beginning of a sustained downturn in oil prices that would persist through most of her mandate. Fiscal capacity to deliver the NDP's election platform was significantly constrained. Several major social-policy initiatives — including AISH indexation — were delayed from their planned early-mandate implementation to the final year of the mandate as a result. The April 16, 2019 election produced a 63-seat UCP majority under Jason Kenney. The NDP held 24 seats; Notley remained leader of the opposition until 2024.

What the Notley government established

The Notley-era record on disability and income-support policy is the longest "established" section in this entire document. Each action below is structurally documented, legislatively traceable, and produced direct improvements in the lives of Albertans with disabilities, low-income Albertans, and seniors during the period the actions were in force.

1. Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act (Bill 205, June 7, 2017)

Bill 205 — the *Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act* — was originally introduced as a private member's bill by Sandra Jansen, MLA for Calgary-North West. Jansen had crossed the floor from the Progressive Conservatives to the NDP in November 2016, and the bill was an early-mandate priority of hers. The Notley government made Bill 205 government business so that it could be debated and passed in the spring 2017 sitting rather than waiting for the next private-members' window. **The bill passed the Legislature unanimously on June 7, 2017.**

Jansen's framing during legislative debate, preserved in Hansard and reported in the Calgary Herald:

"From the feedback we heard, there's a lot that isn't working right right now. And there are no better people to tell us what's not working than people with disabilities who are accessing the system and their advocates currently who are helping them do that."

— Sandra Jansen, MLA Calgary-North West, on Bill 205 in the Alberta Legislature, May 2017

The Act establishes the position of Advocate for Persons with Disabilities, appointed by the Lieutenant Governor in Council. Its statutory functions include representing the rights, interests, and viewpoints of persons with disabilities; providing information and advice to government on issues affecting the community; building partnerships with community groups and individuals with disabilities; and reporting on systemic issues. The first Advocate was appointed by the Notley government in 2018 after public consultation throughout the province. The Act was proclaimed into law in the spring of 2018.

The Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities has continued to operate under the UCP government since 2019. Per Accessibility Services Canada's 2023 summary, Alberta was *"one of the first jurisdictions in Canada to establish an advocate specifically dedicated to persons with disabilities."* The Office has handled over a thousand individual case contacts per year and has, in successive annual reports, called for the establishment of Alberta accessibility legislation. The Notley-era Act is one of the few Notley-era disability-policy initiatives that survived the UCP succession without structural amendment.

2. The \$25-per-day childcare pilot (April 2017 – April 2021)

The Notley NDP campaigned in 2015 on a promise of universal \$25-per-day childcare in Alberta. In April 2017, the government announced a \$10-million pilot project that would provide childcare at a maximum of \$25 per day for children aged zero to six. Phase 1 of the pilot launched at 22 non-profit centres across Alberta. The pilot specifically targeted shift workers and children with special needs — including children with disabilities — for priority placement, an explicit Notley-era policy choice.

In April 2018, the program was expanded to 122 centres, creating 6,000 additional subsidised spaces. The federal Liberal government contributed \$46 million per year over three years through a bilateral childcare agreement. The Government of Alberta's own estimate placed average family savings at approximately \$425 per month for participating families. The Notley government's 2019 re-election platform promised universal

expansion to \$25-per-day for all children five and under province-wide, with 13,000 additional spaces — a \$1.5 billion commitment over five years.

The pilot ended on April 1, 2021 under the Kenney UCP government, which declined to renew the funding. The federal \$10-per-day childcare program signed in 2021 between the Kenney UCP and the federal Trudeau Liberals partially replaced — but did not structurally re-establish — the Notley-era universal pilot. The Notley government's specific framework, with its priority targeting of shift workers and children with special needs, has not been restored.

WHY THE CHILDCARE PROGRAM MATTERS IN A DISABILITY DOCUMENT

Childcare is not, on its face, a disability program. But it is structurally upstream of disability supports in several specific ways. Parents of children with disabilities — particularly the parents of multiple children with disabilities, including many Albertan families known to this campaign — face systemic obstacles to childcare that non-disabled families do not. Specialised care is more expensive, less available, harder to secure, and more frequently rejected. The Notley-era pilot's explicit priority for children with special needs was one of the few moments in modern Alberta policy history when this structural barrier was recognised and partially addressed. Its loss has been absorbed disproportionately by families with disabled children.

3. Minimum wage increase to \$15 per hour (October 1, 2018)

The Notley government raised Alberta's minimum wage from \$10.20 per hour (the rate inherited from the Prentice PC government in May 2015) to \$15 per hour, in staged annual increments, with the final increase taking effect on October 1, 2018. At the time of the final increase, Alberta's minimum wage was the highest in Canada.

The disability-policy significance of the minimum wage is twofold: many AISH recipients work part-time in roles paid at or near the minimum wage; and many family members and caregivers of AISH recipients similarly work in minimum-wage roles to supplement household income. A higher minimum wage produced an immediate, direct increase in the real-term income of these households. The UCP government did not roll back the \$15 rate, but they introduced a sub-minimum tier (\$13/hour for workers under 18) in 2019 that diluted the structural achievement.

4. Bill 26 (NDP version) — "An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities" (November 8, 2018)

The single most consequential disability-policy action of the Notley era. Introduced by Community and Social Services Minister Irfan Sabir on November 8, 2018, the bill — officially titled *An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities* — accomplished four structural changes simultaneously:

- **Indexed AISH, Income Support, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit to the Consumer Price Index (CPI)**, by statute, with automatic annual increases. The first time in Alberta history any of these programs had been indexed.
- **Raised the maximum AISH benefit** from \$1,588 per month to \$1,685 per month for a single person; and from \$1,788 to \$1,985 per month for a single person with two children. The first AISH increase since 2012.
- **Raised the Alberta Seniors Benefit** from \$280 to \$286 per month (the first increase in nearly a decade).
- **Raised AISH and Income Support asset limits** dramatically — child allowance from \$3,000 to \$100,000, and supplementary personal benefits from \$3,000 to \$5,000 — removing the cliff-edge effects that had made it functionally impossible for AISH recipients to accumulate any meaningful savings.

The bill affected approximately 250,000 Albertans. Government cost projections at the time placed the fiscal impact at \$46 million for the remainder of fiscal 2018-19 and \$194 million in fiscal 2019-20. At the time of the bill's introduction, only three Canadian jurisdictions — Yukon, Manitoba, and Quebec — had indexed their disability or income-support payments to inflation. Yukon was the only Canadian jurisdiction to have indexed seniors' benefits. Alberta's Bill 26 placed the province ahead of every comparable Canadian jurisdiction on income-support indexation.

Premier Notley's framing at the bill's introduction is the single most-cited Notley quote in this entire document, and its structural significance for the campaign you are reading the historical record of cannot be overstated:

"Now that it's in the legislation, it would be much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen. It will happen."

— Premier Rachel Notley, on AISH indexation, November 8, 2018

Notley's specific framing — *"in the legislation, much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen"* — reflects her government's explicit theory of how to protect disability supports from future cuts. Statutory indexation makes reduction politically expensive: a government wishing to suspend it must pass new legislation through the Legislature, in public, with a recorded vote. It cannot be done through quiet budget omission, the way the Klein-era AISH freeze was implemented (Phase Three of this piece).

This theory was tested within twelve months and proved insufficient. The Kenney UCP government, in October 2019, suspended the indexation through Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — an omnibus budget-implementation bill. The structural difference between standalone disability-rights legislation and an omnibus budget bill is itself documented in this chapter's framing later.

Community response to the Notley restoration

The disability community's response to Bill 26 (NDP version, 2018) is preserved in Government of Alberta press releases and contemporaneous reporting. Two voices — one from a person with lived experience as an AISH recipient, one from a community-sector leader — capture the structural significance the community

attached to the indexation at the time of its passage:

"This cost-of-living increase means the government recognizes the AISH program needs to change with the times. It will take away the desperation of managing my finances in the face of yearly inflation."

— Ian Young, AISH client, writer, and advocate, November 2018

"We are pleased with the government's decision to increase AISH and the income programs and, most importantly, to index them. Poverty isn't just about money, but it is always about money. These actions will make a big difference in the lives of our most vulnerable Albertans."

— Franco Savoia, Vibrant Communities Calgary, November 2018

Ian Young's framing is structurally important to the broader argument of this document. His description of the pre-indexation reality — *"desperation of managing my finances in the face of yearly inflation"* — is the lived experience of every AISH recipient under every non-indexed regime since 1993. The Notley indexation, for the fifteen months it was in force, removed that desperation by statute. The Kenney suspension restored it.

NDP Bill 26 (2018) and UCP Bill 20 (2019) — the structural reversal

The structural achievement of NDP Bill 26 (2018) was reversed within twelve months by the Kenney UCP government through Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act), introduced October 28, 2019 by Finance Minister Travis Toews. Bill 20 was an omnibus budget-implementation bill that touched dozens of fiscal measures. Among them, in a single clause, was the suspension of the statutory indexation NDP Bill 26 had passed into law twelve months earlier.

NDP BILL 26 (2018) — "An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities"

Introduced November 8, 2018, by Community and Social Services Minister Irfan Sabir. **INDEXED** AISH, Income Support, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit to CPI by statute. Raised AISH base rate from \$1,588 to \$1,685 per month. Raised AISH child-allowance asset limit from \$3,000 to \$100,000. Affected 250,000 Albertans. The most positive single piece of disability legislation in Alberta since 1979.

UCP BILL 20 (2019) — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act

Introduced October 28, 2019, by Finance Minister Travis Toews as an omnibus budget-implementation bill. **DE-INDEXED** AISH, Income Support, Special Needs Assistance, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit. Removed the statutory CPI-indexation mechanism the NDP had passed twelve months earlier. Bill 20 also de-indexed tax brackets (saving the government a separate \$600M+ by 2022-23 in foregone tax adjustment for inflation). Projected AISH-specific savings: \$209.8M through fiscal 2022-23. The structural reversal of NDP Bill 26 (2018) is the substance of Phase Seven of this piece.

The two bills carry different numbers but produce directly contradictory effects on the disability community. In all subsequent references, this document distinguishes them by their government of origin and bill name: *NDP Bill 26 (2018) — An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities* — = indexed. *UCP Bill 20 (2019) — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act* — = de-indexed. The UCP's choice to embed the de-indexation inside an omnibus budget bill, rather than in standalone legislation, is itself structurally significant: it minimised the individual political visibility of the disability-specific cut by surrounding it with dozens of other measures. The disability community absorbed the cost regardless.

What the Notley government did not do

Notley's record on disability policy is, within the scope of this document, unambiguously the most positive of the seven eras documented. It is also, on honest accounting, incomplete. Three structural omissions warrant naming.

1. The indexation came late

Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) was introduced on November 8, 2018 — five months before the next general election. The government had been in office for three and a half years before introducing the legislation. The election that followed produced a 63-seat UCP majority. The UCP, in subsequent debate, accused the NDP of having waited until the final year of its mandate to act on a policy it had committed to in 2015.

Notley's response to that criticism, at the time of Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) introduction, was that an oil-price collapse had forced the indexation timeline to be delayed. The documented record supports that account — Alberta's oil-revenue base contracted significantly through 2015-2016, and fiscal capacity to implement the indexation was constrained. But the timing of the bill's introduction — November 2018, five months before an election the NDP was expected to lose — is structurally significant. The indexation took effect on January 1, 2019. The government that would have been responsible for implementing the first scheduled indexed increase the

following year was no longer the NDP. **The Notley government enacted indexation. It did not implement an indexed increase.** The UCP suspended the mechanism before the first scheduled increase could occur.

2. No accessibility legislation

By the time the Notley NDP took office, Manitoba, Ontario, Nova Scotia, and the federal government had either passed or were actively drafting comprehensive accessibility legislation. The federal Accessible Canada Act would pass in 2019, applying barrier-removal standards to federal sectors. The Notley government did not introduce a comparable Alberta Accessibility Act, despite the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (established under Bill 205) calling for one in its first annual report.

As of May 2026 — the date of this document's first publication — Alberta remains, alongside Prince Edward Island, one of only two Canadian provinces or territories without a comprehensive accessibility statute. The Notley government had the political majority and the legislative time to pass one. It did not. The omission is one of the structural reasons the ADSB campaign is now proposing the *Alberta Accessibility and Inclusion Act* as a separate workstream from the AISH-to-ADAP transition: the framework Notley did not build remains unbuilt seven years after her election loss.

3. PDD review did not produce structural change

The Notley government announced a major review of the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program in January 2018. The review's findings produced recommendations for the UCP government, but the structural rebalancing of PDD that the review identified as necessary was not enacted before the Notley mandate ended in April 2019. The PDD program continues to operate today on substantially the framework Klein established in 1997 (Phase Three), with the cumulative downward drift documented in subsequent chapters.

Caseload context

AISH caseload through the Notley years continued the steady growth pattern that has operated since the late 1990s. Approximately 48,000 recipients at the beginning of the mandate (May 2015) grew to approximately 67,000 by the end of the mandate (April 2019). The growth rate during the Notley years was higher than under any prior era in this piece, reflecting both demographic expansion and the broadening of qualifying diagnostic categories — particularly mental health diagnoses — that had begun under Stelmach and continued under Redford.

The growth in caseload during a period of indexation produced compound fiscal effects the UCP government would subsequently cite as justification for the 2019 indexation suspension. The structural argument that growing caseloads in an indexed program produce growing total program costs is mathematically correct. The same argument, applied to the assured income side of the AISH founding bargain, structurally abandons the bargain itself: AISH was designed to provide assured income to all Albertans who meet the diagnostic criteria. The Notley government honoured that founding bargain. The Kenney government, in suspending indexation, did not.

The Notley conclusion

Rachel Notley governed Alberta for four years. Her government delivered the largest single-mandate package of disability-policy reforms in modern Alberta history. The package included statutory CPI indexation of AISH (the first and only time this has been done in Alberta history); the first significant AISH base-rate increase since 2012; the creation of an independent Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities; the universal \$25-per-day childcare pilot with explicit priority for children with special needs; and the minimum wage increase to \$15 per hour.

Her government also did not enact comprehensive accessibility legislation, did not complete a structural restructure of the PDD program, and did not implement the AISH indexation it had legislated. The reasons for those omissions are partly fiscal and partly political, and the documented record establishes both.

The single most consequential lesson of the Notley era — for this document, for the ADSB campaign, and for every disability advocacy organisation operating in Alberta in 2026 — is the one Notley herself named on November 8, 2018. She believed that putting indexation *"in the legislation"* would make it *"much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen."* She was wrong, but not because her reasoning was wrong. She was wrong because the UCP government that succeeded her chose to make it discretionary again. Statutory protection only works if the successor government chooses to honour the statute.

The structural conclusion this document draws from the Notley era is that **statutory protection of disability supports is necessary but not sufficient**. What is also required is something the Notley era did not, and could not, supply: a community-led representational structure that does not depend on which party is in government to maintain its functions. The Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities is the partial structural answer — a non-partisan, statutorily-protected office that has continued to function under the UCP, even as the substantive policies it advocates for have been reversed. But the Advocate is one position. The disability community is approximately 730,000 Albertans. The structural representation gap that remains is the gap the ADSB campaign now exists to begin filling.

Phase Seven of this piece documents the Jason Kenney UCP era, 2019 – 2022 — the era in which the structural reversal of every major Notley-era social-policy gain was executed. The reversal began on Day One.

By the time Kenney resigned in May 2022, the Notley restoration had been substantially undone. The community has been absorbing the cost of that reversal ever since.

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The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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